THE VIRAL FEVER / LCX

TVF Lead Engine

How to use it, screen by screen

The Viral Fever / LCX

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What this tool is

The Lead Engine finds companies and people worth emailing, gathers the evidence for why they are worth emailing, scores them, writes a first email to each one, and holds every email until a person reads it and says yes.

It does not send anything on its own. That is the whole design.

There are two halves:

The engine runs on its own. It searches YouTube, Apple Podcasts, Wikidata and news feeds, reads public pages, works out who is behind a show or a studio, scores each one against a written rubric, and writes a draft email built from that company's own numbers.

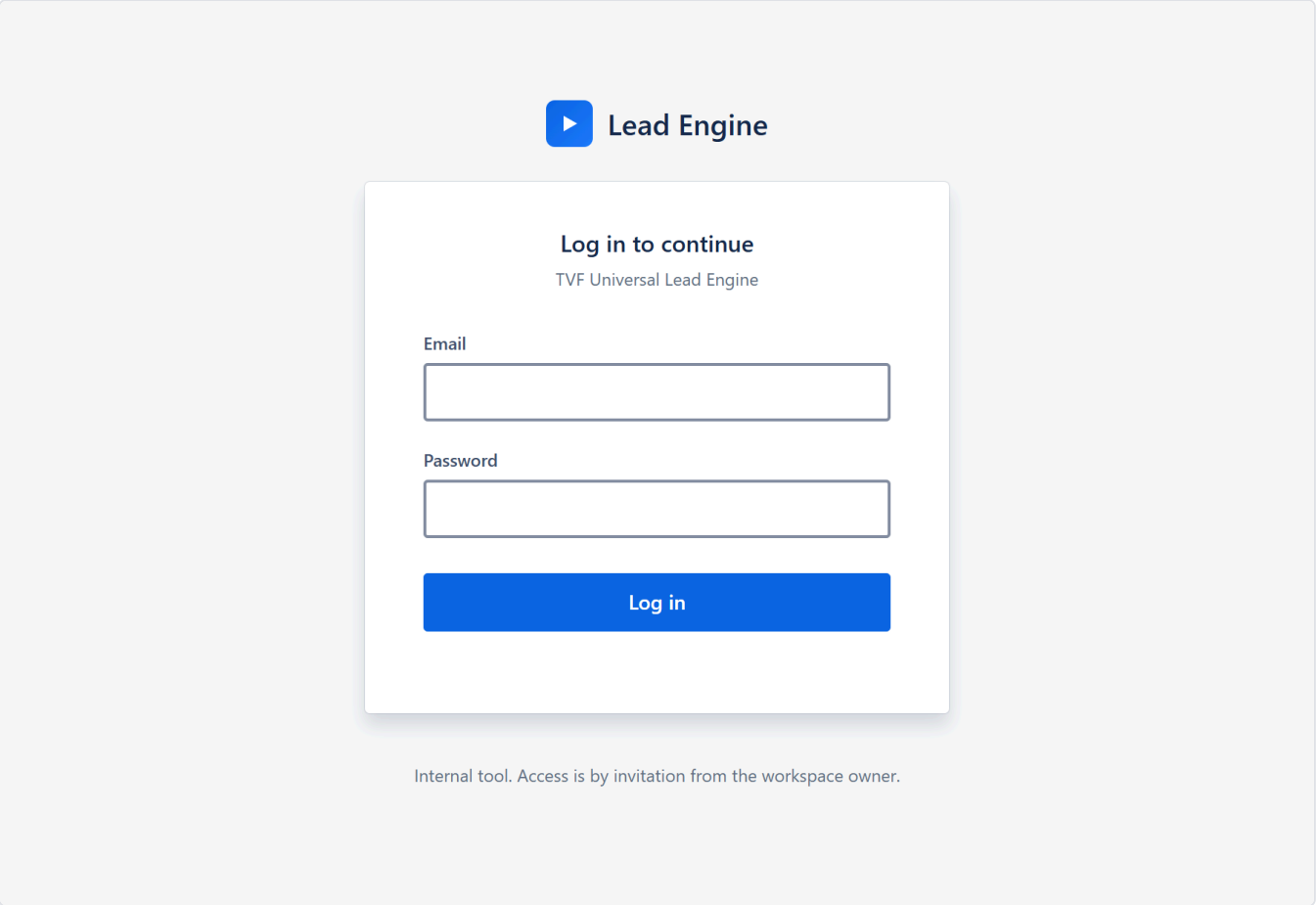
You do the part a machine should not do. You look at what it found, decide yes or no, read the emails it wrote, and approve the ones you stand behind.

A normal day is twenty minutes: open the board, work through the new leads, shortlist the good ones, then read and approve the emails that were drafted overnight.

> The screenshots in this manual come from the real app, loaded with a snapshot of the live pool. The email addresses in them end in `example.com` because a manual gets shared and a real prospect's address does not belong in a PDF.

Getting in

Open the site in any browser. You will be asked to log in.



The sign-in screen

The first time anyone ever opens it, the screen asks you to create the owner account instead: an email address and a password of at least ten characters. That account is created once and only once.

To give a colleague access, the owner runs this on their machine:

```
python tools/users.py add teammate@theviralfever.com
```

It asks for a password, twice, and never puts it in a command. `users.py list` shows who has access, `passwd` resets a forgotten password, and `remove` takes access away.

There is no "sign up" link and no password reset by email. That is deliberate. Everything in this tool sits behind that one login, including every screen, every number and every draft email.

The shape of the app

Down the left is the menu. Five places, and you will live in three of them.

WHERE	WHAT IT IS FOR
Board	The pipeline at a glance. Cards move left to right as you decide on them.
Leads	The full list, with search and filters. Better than the board once you have hundreds.
Outreach	Every email. Drafts waiting for you, approved ones, sent ones, and replies.
Reports	Are we finding enough? Are we contacting enough? Is the scoring working?
Operations	Run the engine by hand, see what is scheduled, check the mailboxes.

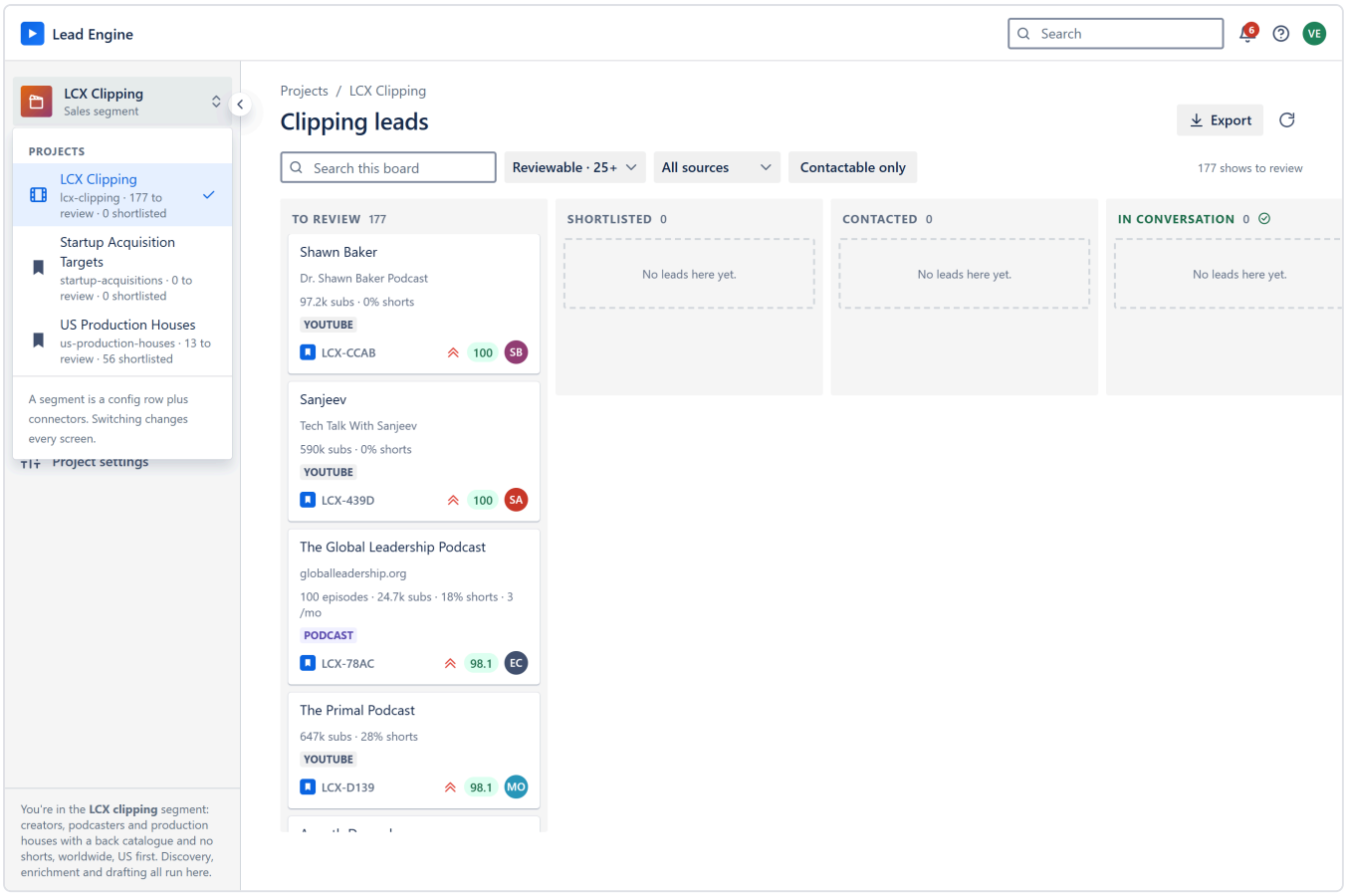
Below those: **Generate leads** starts a harvest, and **Project settings** shows the rubric this project scores against.

The Universal project has a different menu: **Apollo search** sits at the top, because that is where its leads come from, and Outreach, Operations and Generate leads are not there.

Switching between projects

A **project** (the code calls it a segment) is one sales motion with its own leads, its own rubric, its own email templates and its own mailboxes. Nothing leaks between them.

Click the project name at the very top of the left sidebar to switch.



Click the project at the top of the sidebar to switch

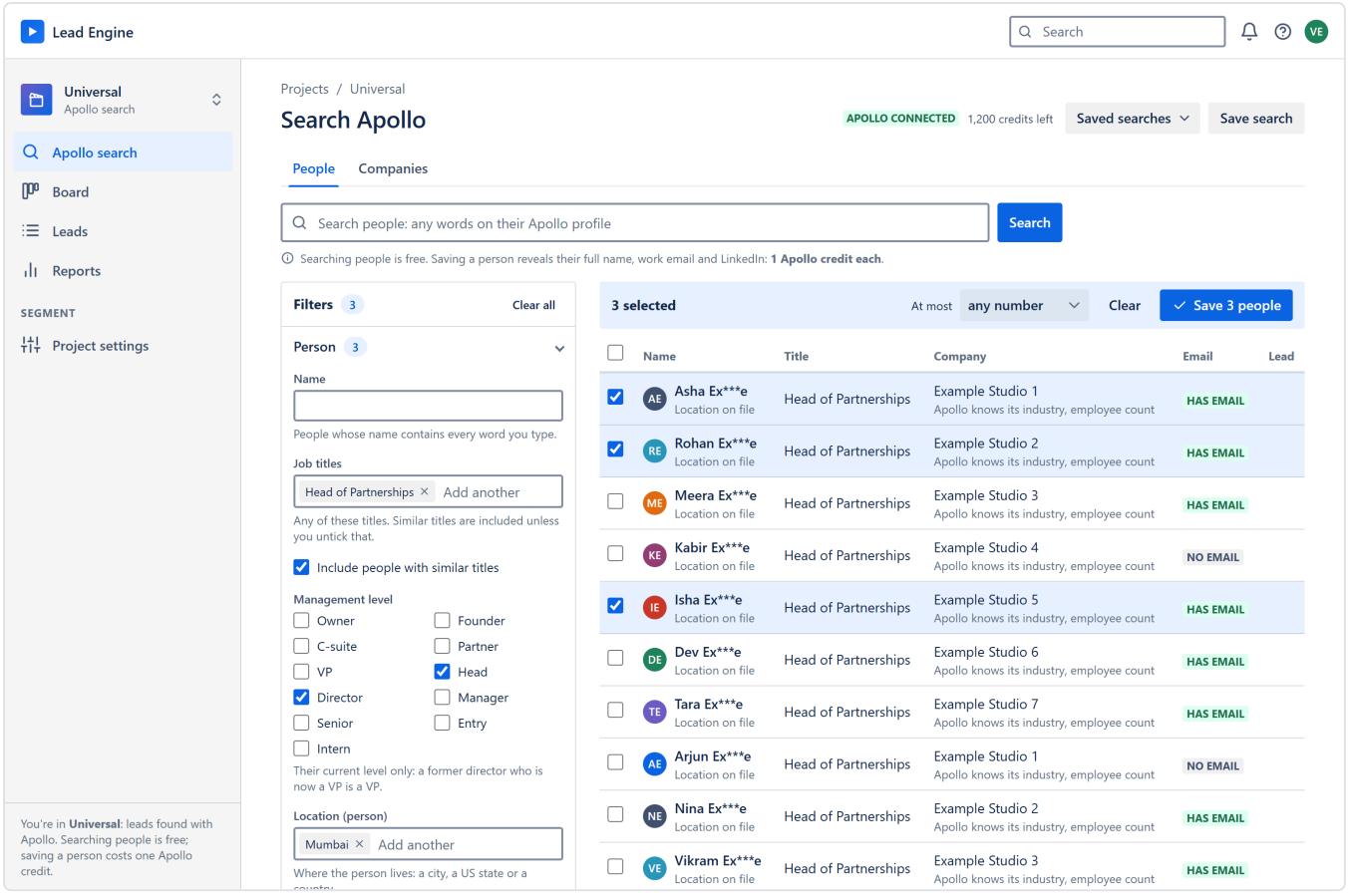
Right now there are four:

- **LCX Clipping** — creators, podcasters and production houses with a deep back catalogue and almost no short-form. This is the active one.
- **US Production Houses** — TVF co-production targets.
- **Startup Acquisitions** — Mumbai startups showing public signs of struggle, which TVF could buy for little or back with its content and audience.
- **Universal** — any company or person, found with Apollo. No rubric and no harvest: you search, you pick, you save.

Whichever project you pick, every screen changes with it. The board, the leads, the emails, the reports. Check the sidebar if you are ever unsure which one you are looking at.

Universal: searching Apollo

The Universal project finds leads anywhere, through Apollo. Pick it from the project menu and it opens on **Apollo search**.



Apollo search, in the Universal project

Two searches, as in Apollo's own app. *People* finds people; *Companies* finds companies. Type in the search bar, or set filters on the left, then press **Search**. The filters carry the names Apollo gives them:

- **Person**: name, job titles (with or without similar titles), management level, where they live, email status.
- **Company**: HQ location (a company search can also leave locations out), number of employees, industry and keywords, revenue, company domains, and domains to leave out.
- **Technologies** the company uses, **funding**, **job postings**, and **headcount growth** over 6, 12 or 24 months.
- **Company lookalikes**: press **Lookalikes** on a company to find others like it.

A few of Apollo's filters exist only inside its own app: buying intent, departments, past job titles and some others. The bottom of the filter column names them, so nobody goes looking.

What it costs. The credits left show at the top right.

	APOLLO CREDITS
Searching people	none
Saving a person (reveals their name, work email and LinkedIn)	1 each, only when Apollo finds them
One page of company results	1
Saving companies	none

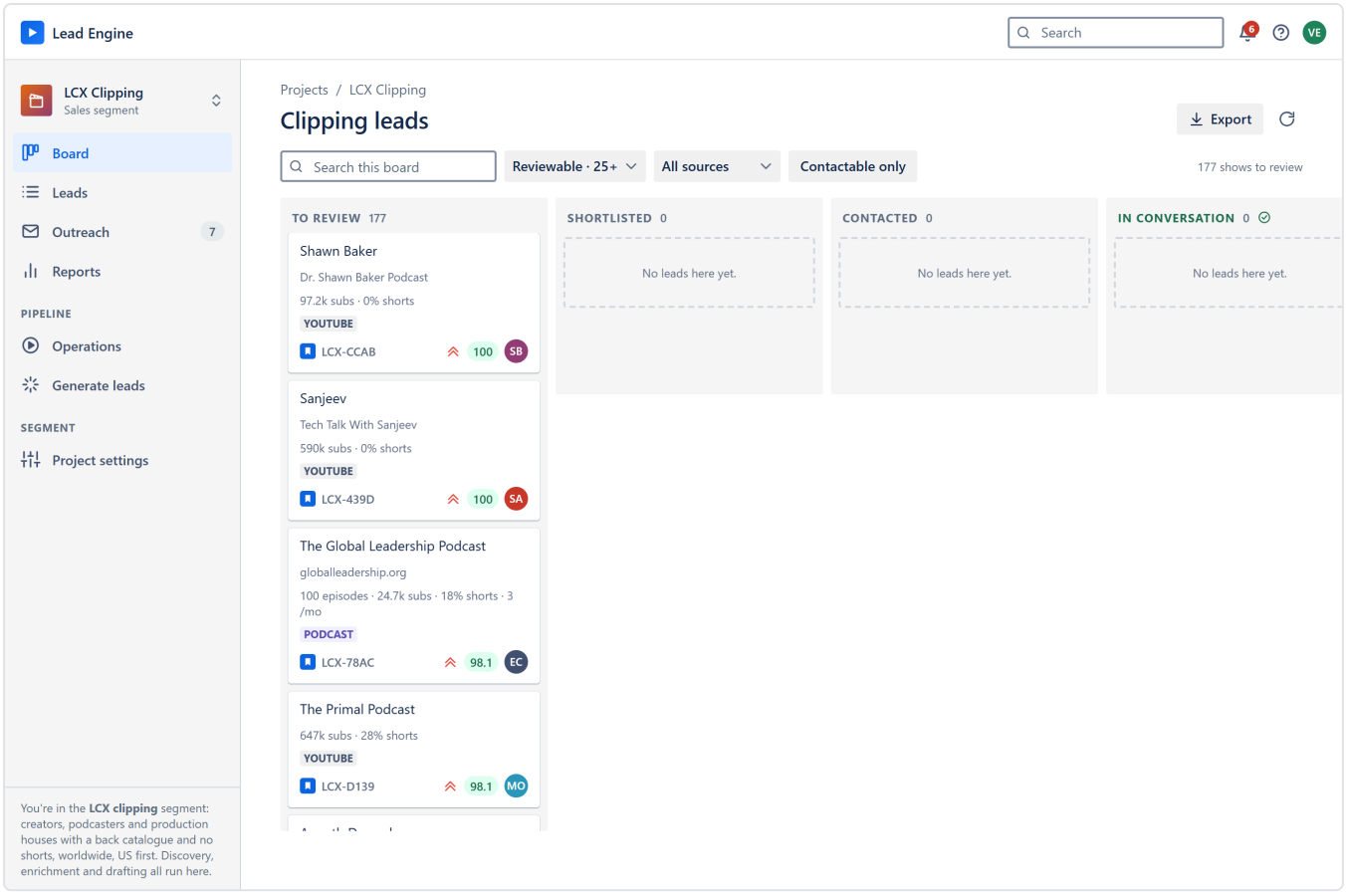
Saving people always asks first, and says the most it can cost.

Saving. Tick the people or companies worth keeping and press **Save**. Each company becomes a lead and each person a contact on it, on this project's Board and Leads pages, where you shortlist or reject them as in any other project. *At most N per company* stops one company filling the list. Nobody already saved is paid for twice, and TVF's own people, and anything rejected before, are never saved.

People at a company. In a company search, **People here** switches to a free people search at that company. Tick several companies and press **Find people at these companies** to do the same for all of them.

Saved searches. Save search keeps the search bar and every filter under a name, and **Saved searches** runs one again. A saved company search waits for you to press Search, because it costs a credit.

The board



The board: everything the engine found, by where it sits

Four columns, left to right. A lead only ever moves forward.

To review — the engine found it and scored it. Nobody has decided yet. This is your inbox.

Shortlisted — you said yes, or in LCX Clipping it scored above 20. It gets an email.

Contacted — an email has been sent. The engine will not start a second thread with this company, ever.

In conversation — they replied and the reply was a real one. Your job now, not the tool's.

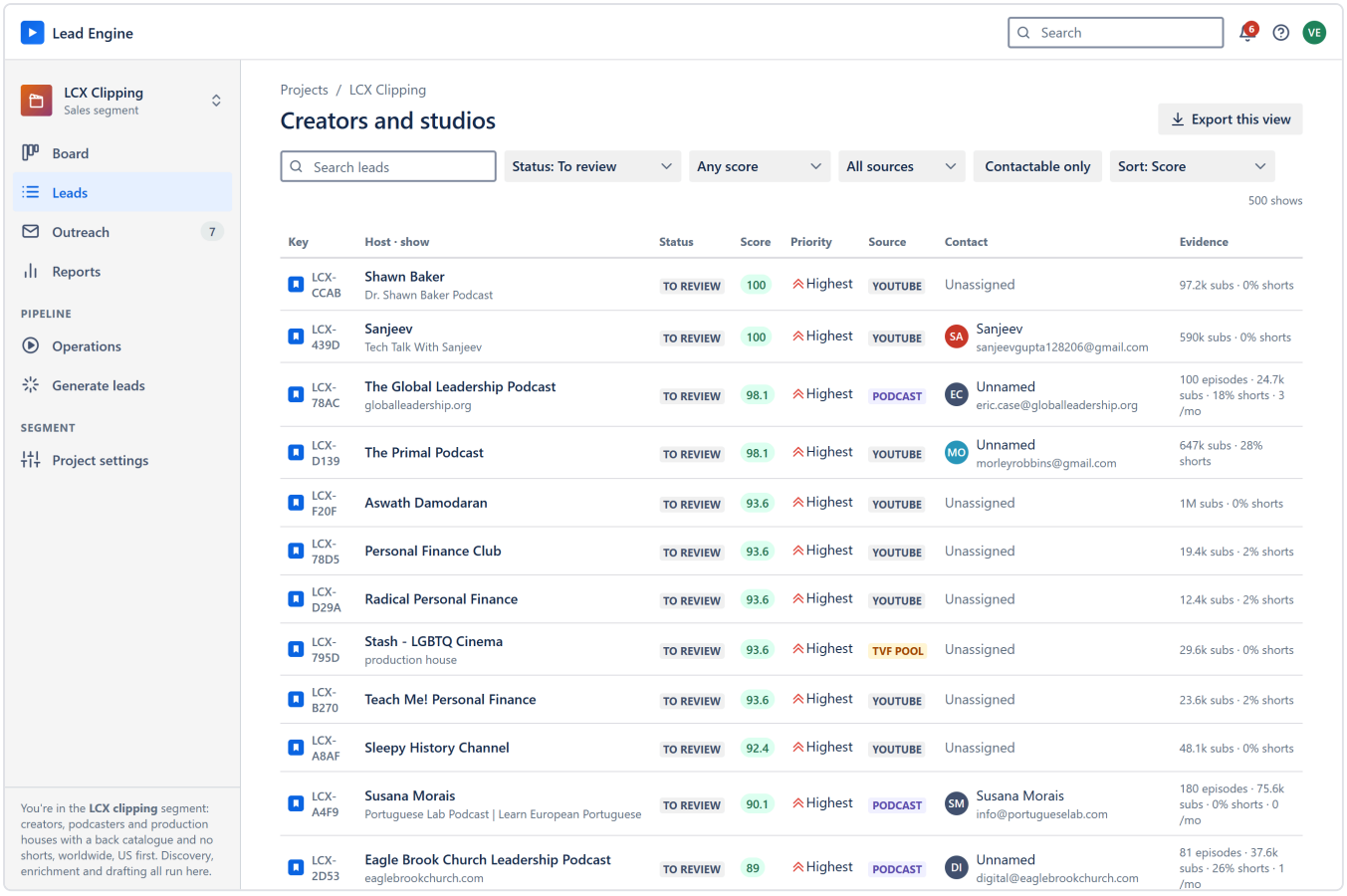
Above the columns are a search box and three filters: score, source, and **Contactable only**, which hides everything the engine has no address for.

Reading a card

Each card shows the person first when the engine could work out who is behind the show, and the show or company underneath. Below that are the numbers that made it interesting: subscribers, how much short-form it publishes, how many episodes, how often.

On the bottom row: the lead's key (like `LCX-CCAB`, the name you can quote to a colleague), a priority arrow, and the fit score, **out of 100** and explained in full inside the lead. 25 and up is worth a look; 45 and up is the priority band.

The leads list



The same leads as a list, with filters

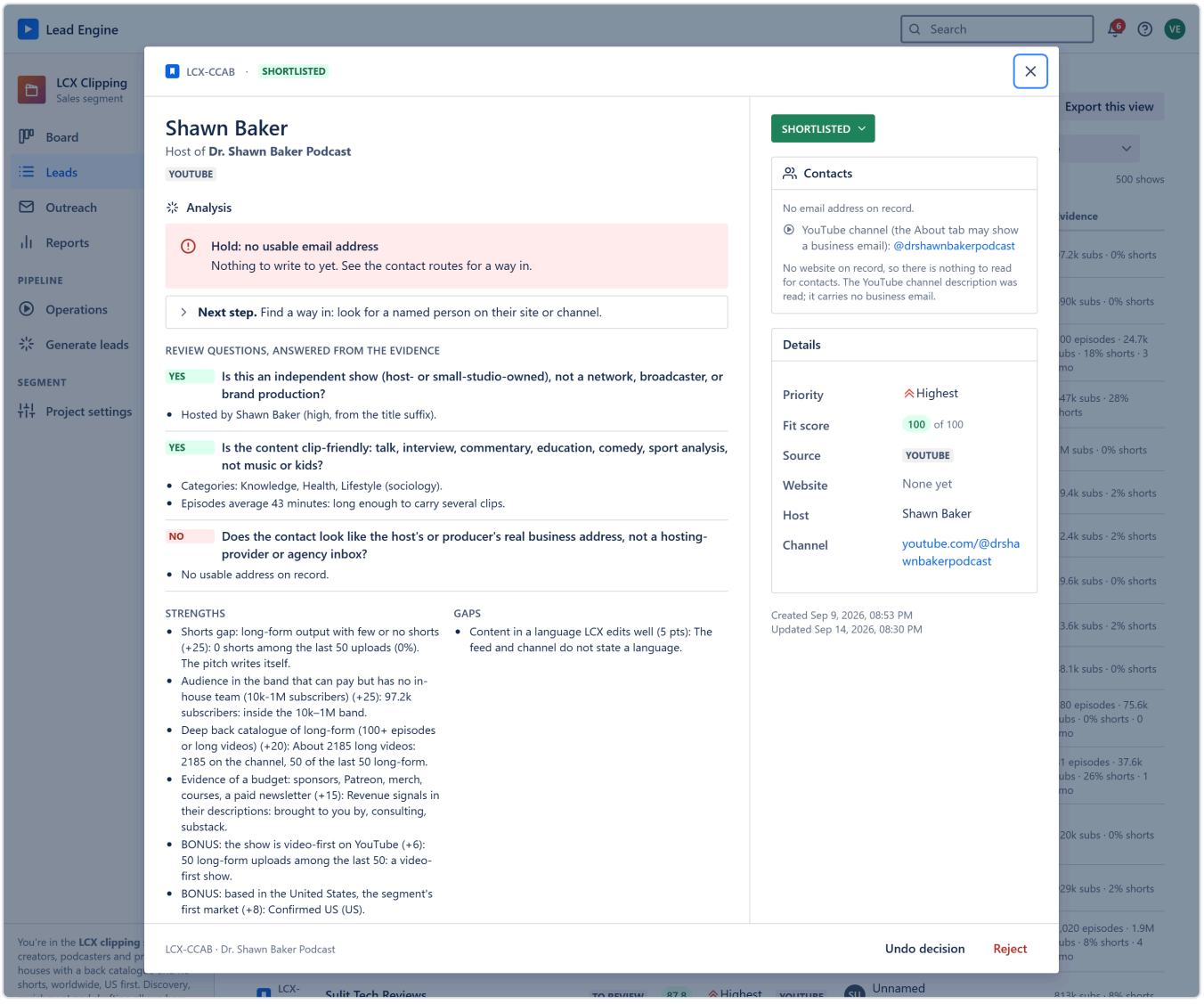
The board is nice for twenty leads. Past that, use this.

Search matches the show name, the host's name and the website. The filters along the top narrow by status, by score, by which connector found it, and by whether there is a contact. **Export this view** downloads exactly what you are looking at as a spreadsheet.

Click anywhere on a row to open it.

Deciding on a lead

This is the main job. Click any row or card.



Everything the engine knows, and the two buttons that matter

Read it top to bottom:

Analysis comes first. It gives the engine's verdict and one suggested next step. Then it answers the project's review questions from the evidence: yes, no or unclear, with the facts behind each answer and what is still missing. Last come strengths, gaps and risks. A blocker, such as a public company or no usable address, puts the lead on hold whatever its score.

Why this could fit is one honest sentence built from their real numbers.

Evidence is the raw facts, each one a thing the engine actually observed: subscribers, videos, how many of the last 50 uploads were long-form, how many were shorts, the average length, how often they publish, and any sign they spend money (sponsors, Patreon, merch, a paid newsletter). Evidence withdrawn on review stays listed, struck through, with the reason.

Score breakdown shows every criterion: what it is worth, what this lead earned, why, and a link to the evidence. Each criterion is in one of three states:

- **Found** — evidence earned points. The source is linked.
- **Checked, nothing found** — a pass looked (it read their website, searched the news, profiled the channel) and found nothing. It scores 0, and that zero means something.
- **Not checked yet** — nobody has looked. It also scores 0 for now, so the score is a floor: checking can only raise it. The row says what would check it: an Operations job, or what to look at by hand.

The bar above the table shows how much of the score has actually been checked. When most of the points are unchecked, the analysis says **Too little checked to trust the score**. The score is the points earned out of the rubric's 110, scaled to 100, plus any adjustments.

On the right, **Contacts** lists every address, best first. **Drafts use this** marks the address the email goes to. Addresses that cannot be used, such as a website template's placeholder or a scraping artefact, are struck through with the reason. Below them are the other ways in: a phone number, people listed without an address, the contact page, social profiles, the channel or feed, and what has already been tried. Open the website or channel and look at it before you decide. Thirty seconds there beats any rubric.

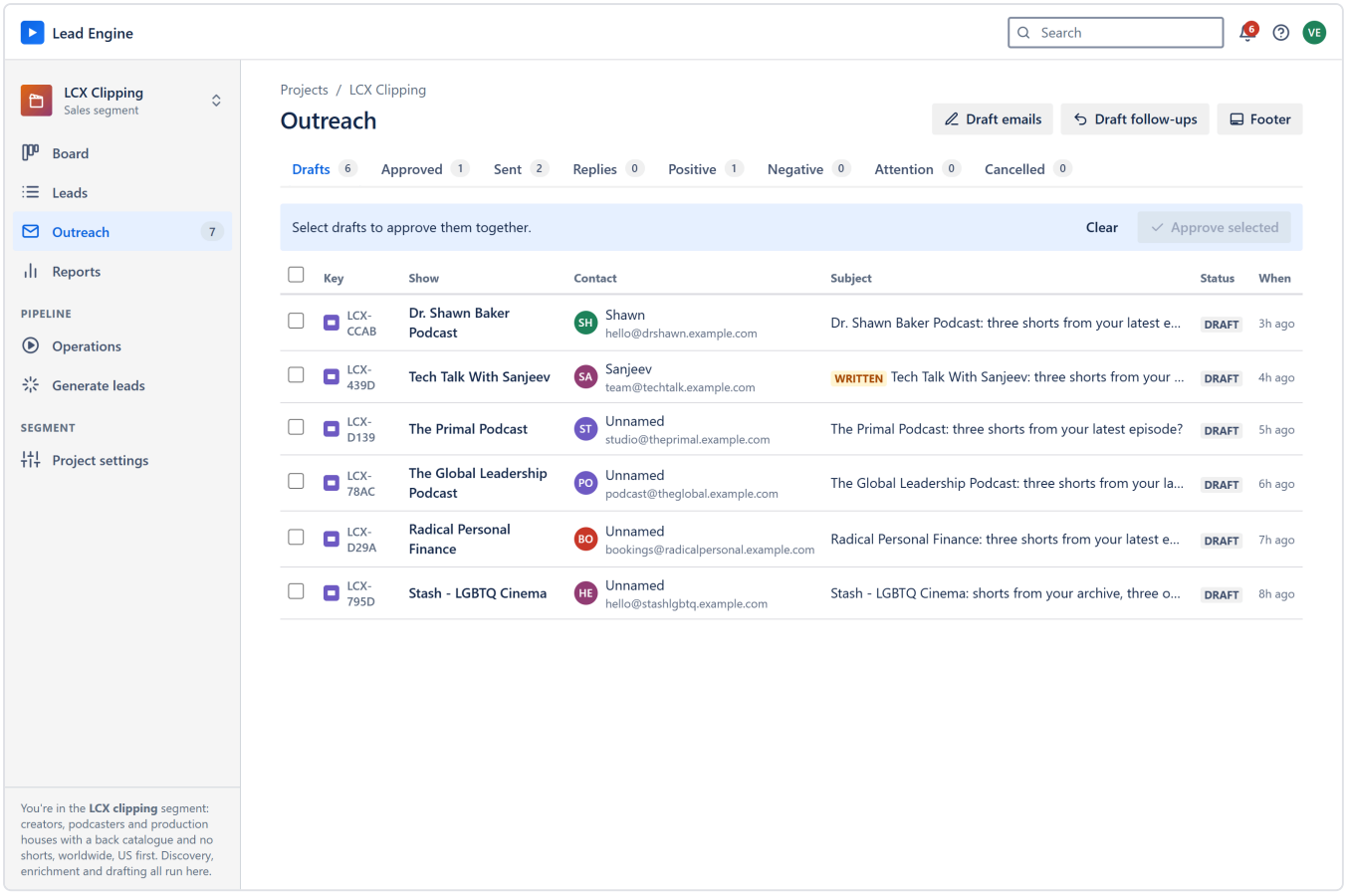
Then press one of two buttons at the bottom:

Shortlist — the engine will write this one an email. In LCX Clipping you will rarely need it: every lead scoring above 20 is shortlisted automatically after each refresh, and its dialog says so. If you move one back to review, that stands; the rule never shortlists it again.

Reject — it leaves the pipeline. A rejected lead is shielded permanently: no later harvest, re-import or reset will bring it back. If you reject something by mistake, reopen it from the Leads list with the status filter set to Rejected and use the status dropdown at the top right of the dialog.

Outreach

Every email lives here, in folders.



The Drafts folder: emails waiting to be read

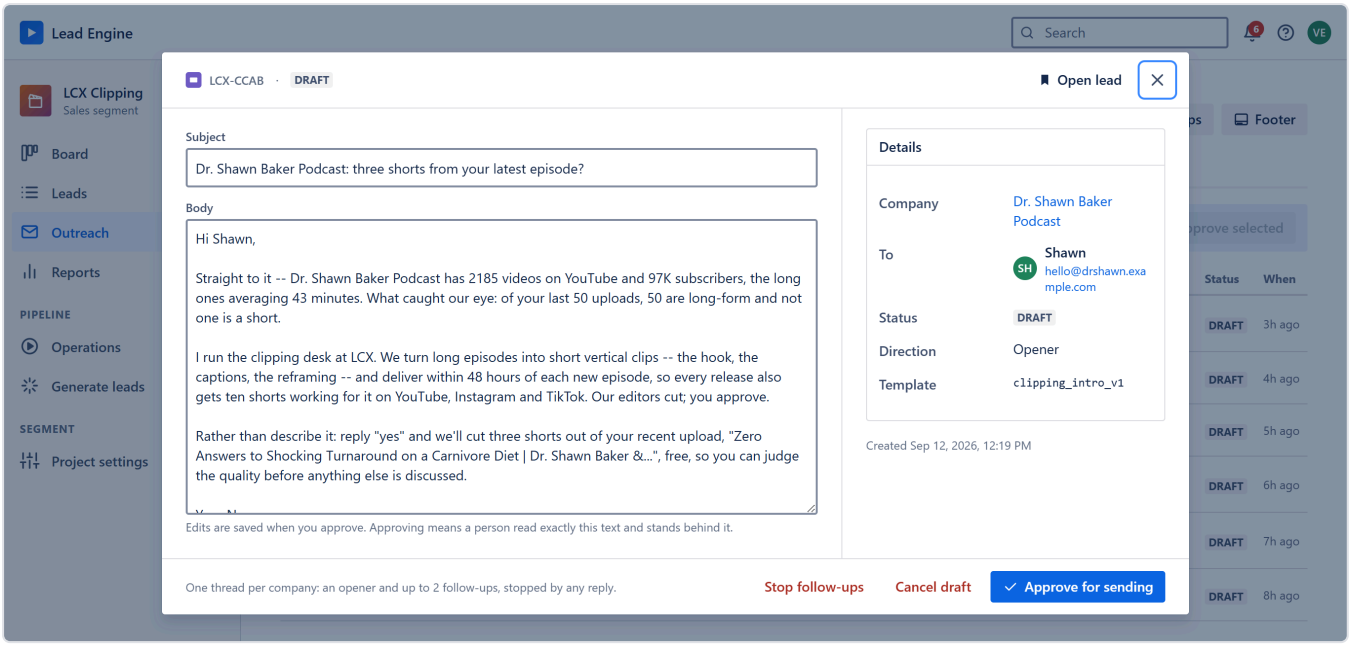
FOLDER	WHAT IS IN IT
Drafts	Written by the engine. Nothing has been sent. Waiting for you.
Approved	You said yes. Waiting for the next send run.
Sent	Gone.
Replies	Came back, not yet judged.
Positive / Negative	Replies you or the triage step have labelled.
Attention	Something went wrong with a send. Look at these.
Cancelled	Withdrawn before sending.

Two buttons at the top right:

Draft emails writes a first email for every shortlisted lead that does not have one yet. **Draft follow-ups** writes the follow-ups that have come due. Both only create drafts; neither sends anything.

Approving one email

Click any row in Drafts.



A draft, with the Approve button

The subject and the body are editable. Change anything you like: the whole point is that what you approve is what goes out, word for word.

Notice what is personal in it. The greeting is the first name of the person the email goes to, never the show's or the company's name. In LCX Clipping the opening sentence is their own numbers, and the offer names their actual most recent episode. None of that was invented; all of it came from the evidence on the lead. Internal research notes never go into an email.

Production-house emails follow the owner's template, in four paragraphs: who Kartikeya is and what TVF makes; which is why this company caught our attention; the partnership and why it fits; a short call. They are signed "Warm regards, Kartikeya, Business Development and IP Strategy". The wording for the company's lane (animation, documentary, digital-first, drama or general) is the owner's own. The second paragraph is written from what the company says about itself on its website, its work and its founders, and it never names anything that is not on record. With a named person the email opens "Hello Becky, I trust you are well."; with none, "Hello,".

Some drafts carry a **Written** mark: a model wrote the opening sentence from that same evidence and nothing else, with every number in it checked against the evidence before it was kept. A written draft is approved on its own, never in a batch, because a random sample cannot stand for a sentence written once for one company.

Approve for sending records your name against the email and moves it to Approved.

Cancel draft throws it away.

Stop follow-ups ends the whole thread with that company. No further follow-up will ever be drafted for them.

Approving does not send

Approving marks an email as ready. The send happens when someone runs this in a terminal:

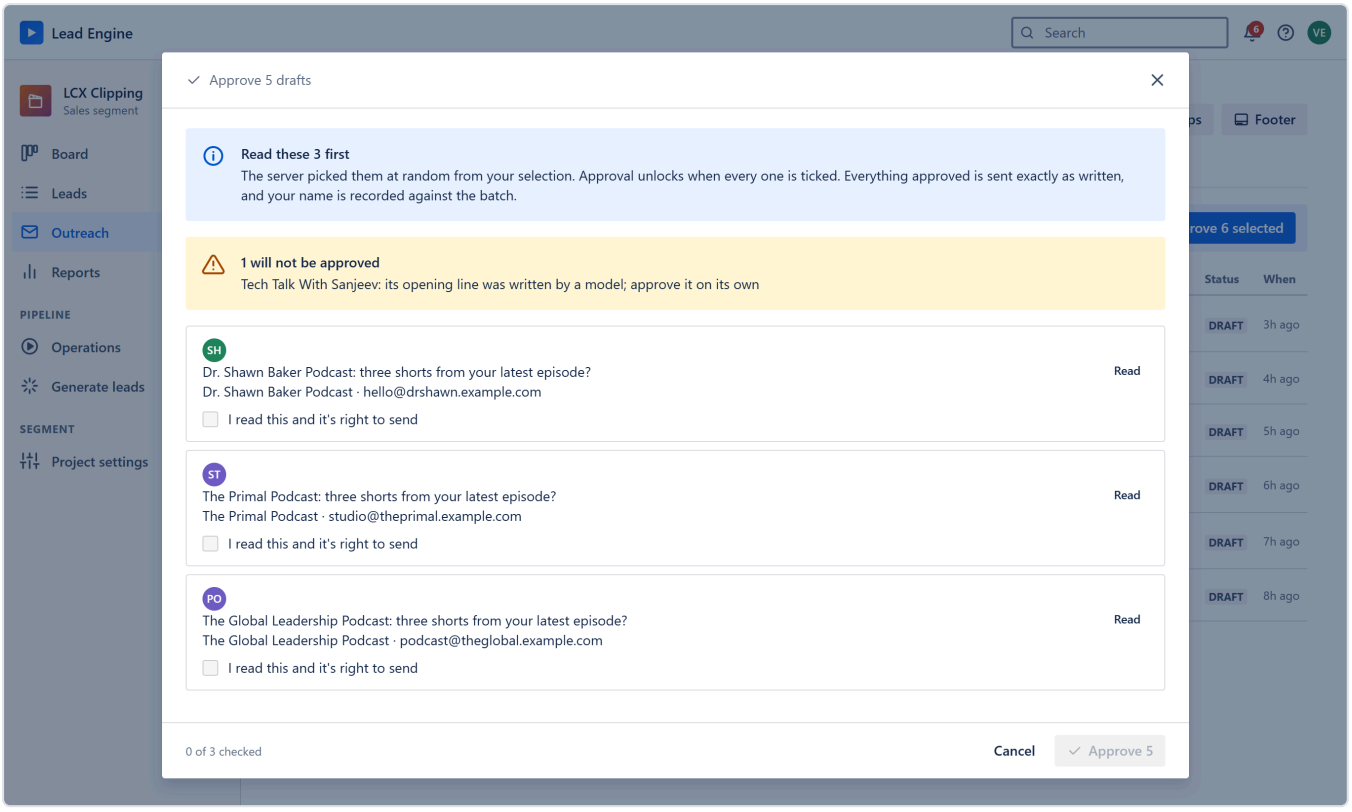
```
SEGMENT_SLUG=lcx-clipping python tools/outreach.py send
```

It sends only approved emails, within the daily cap, never to an address that failed verification. Nothing on any screen can send an email.

Approving many at once

Reading six hundred emails one at a time is not realistic, so the app has a second route that is still honest about what you read.

1. Tick the checkbox on each draft you want, or the one in the header to take the whole page.
2. A bar appears at the top. Press **Approve N selected**.
3. The server picks a random sample from your selection and shows you those.



You read a random sample the server picked; everything else follows

You have to read each one in the sample and tick it before the Approve button turns on. The sample is at least three, or one in ten, whichever is bigger, and you cannot choose which ones you get. Every email in the batch is checked first for unfilled placeholders, a missing sender, a bad address or a company that has moved on; anything that fails is left behind and named.

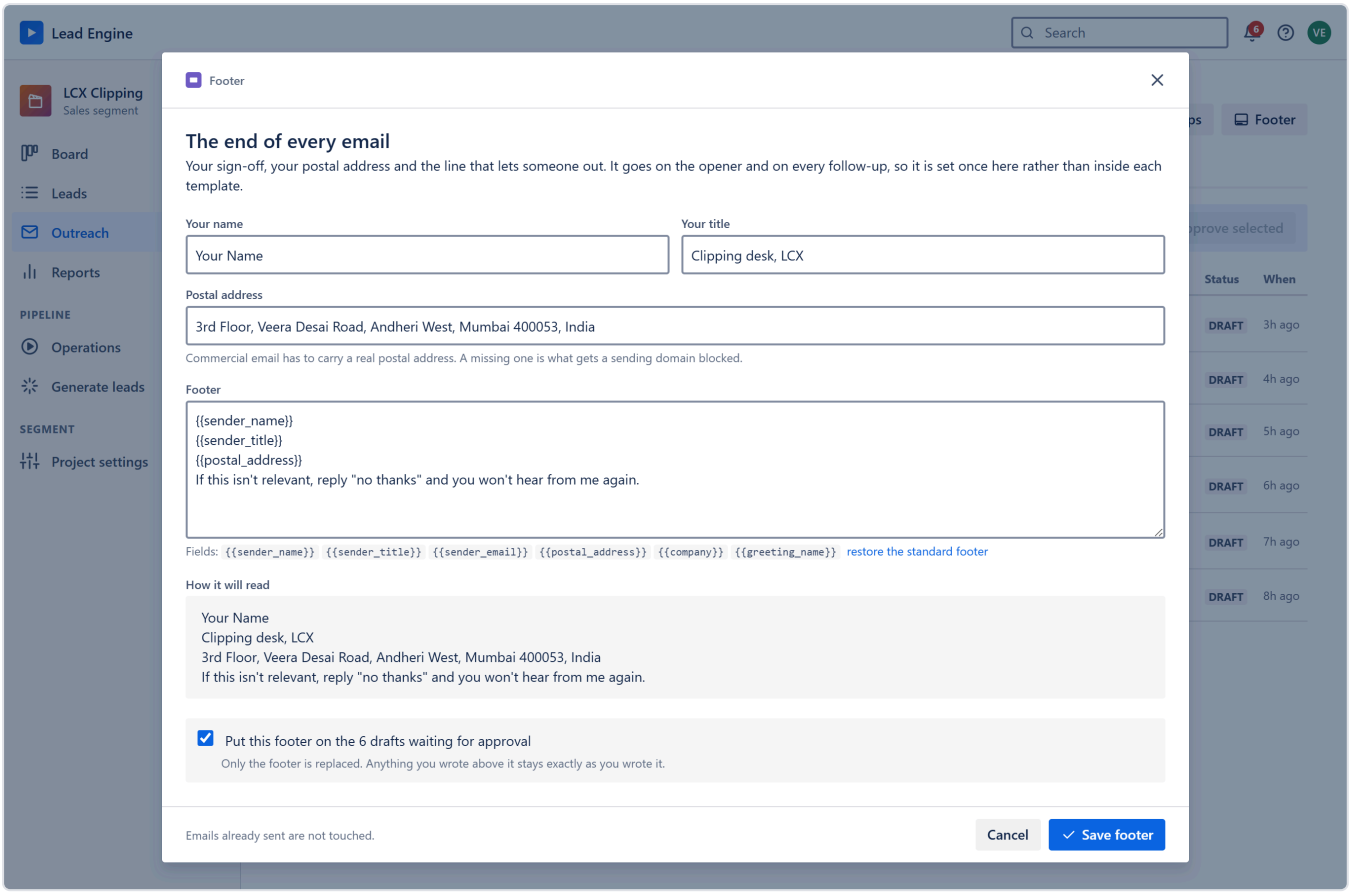
Afterwards, each email records your name, the batch it belonged to, and whether it was one of the ones you actually read.

Batch approval is on for LCX Clipping only. The TVF projects still require one approval per email.

The footer

The sign-off, the postal address and the line that lets someone out are the same on every email. They are one setting, not four lines buried in each template.

Press **Footer** at the top of the Outreach screen.



Your name, your address, and the block every email ends with

Fill in your name, your title and your postal address. The preview underneath shows exactly how the block will read.

Two things it will not let you do:

- **Save without a postal address.** Commercial email has to carry one, and a missing address is the fastest way to get a sending domain blocked.
- **Save without a way out.** Keep the line that tells the recipient how to stop hearing from you. It is the law, and it is the difference between a reply and a spam report.

When you save, it offers to put the new footer on the drafts already waiting for approval. Only the footer is replaced; anything you wrote by hand above it stays exactly as you wrote it. Emails already sent are never touched.

Follow-ups

For LCX Clipping, one company gets one thread: the opener, then up to two follow-ups in the same email thread.

- **Follow-up 1** four days after the opener.
- **Follow-up 2** seven days after that.
- Then the thread is closed for good.

Any reply stops it immediately. A genuine reply ends the thread; an out-of-office lets it resume. This is enforced in the database, not just in the app, so a follow-up cannot be sent to someone who has already written back even if something else goes wrong.

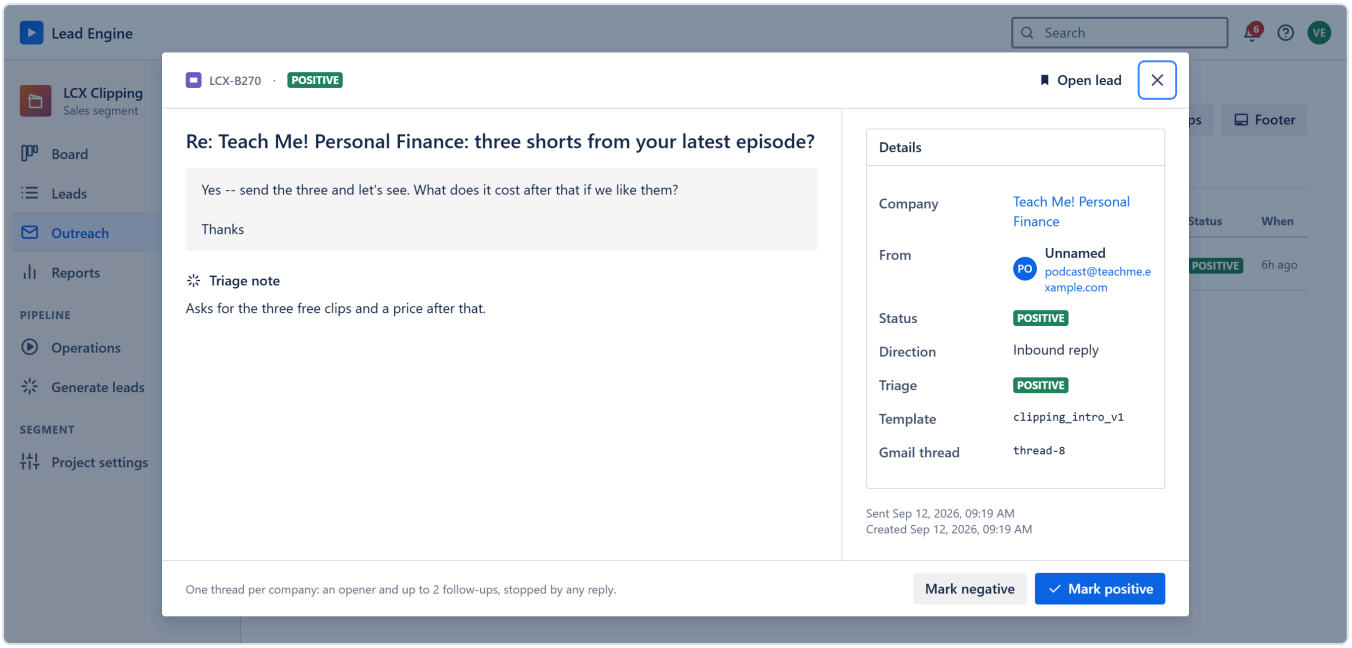
Follow-ups are drafts like any other email and need the same approval. Press **Draft follow-ups** to write the ones that are due, then read and approve them.

To stop a thread by hand, open any message in it and press **Stop follow-ups**.

The TVF projects do not use follow-ups at all. One email per company, full stop.

Replies

When someone writes back, their reply appears in **Replies**. Open it.



A reply, with the two buttons that close the loop

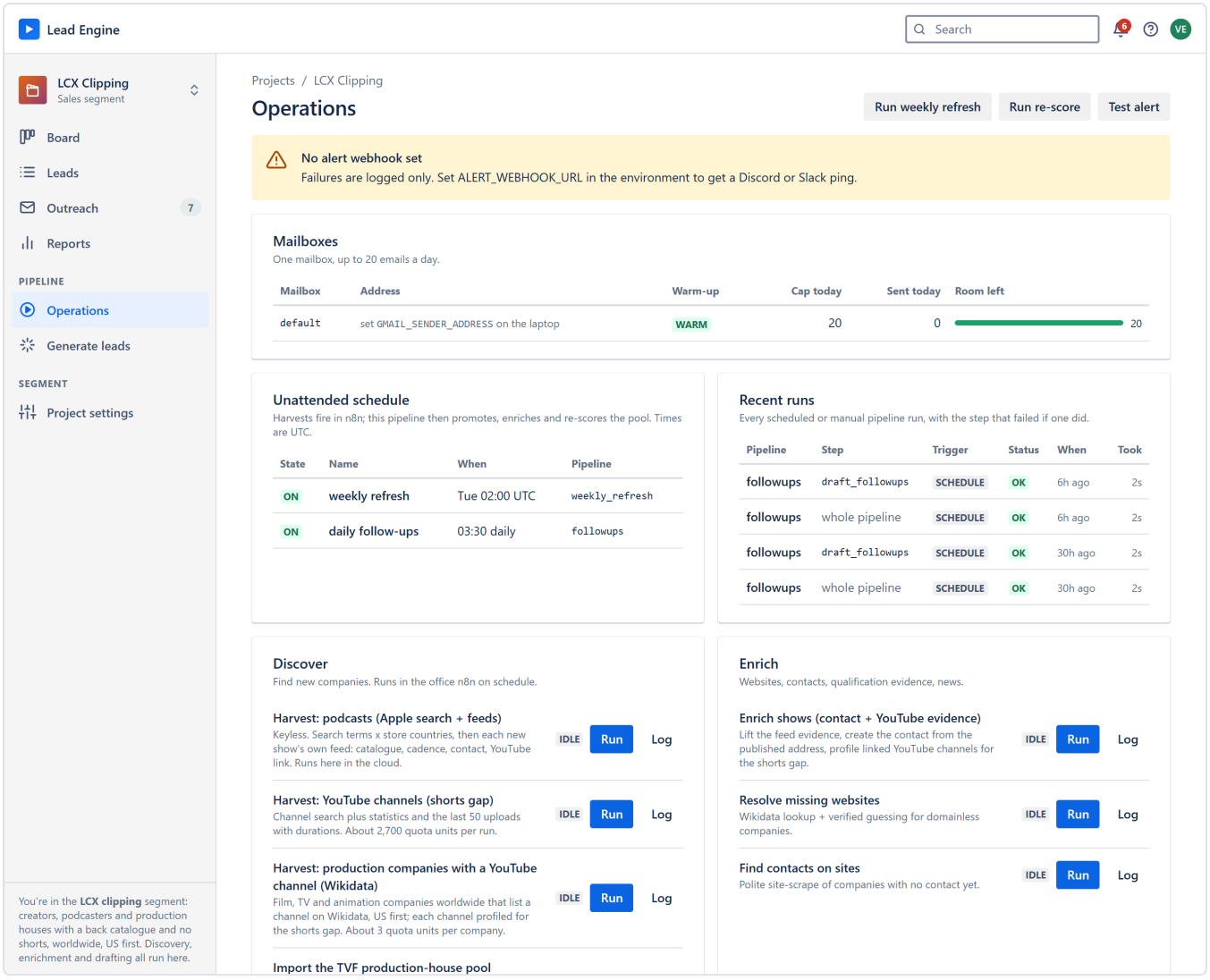
You mark it **Positive** or **Negative**.

Positive moves the company to **In conversation** on the board and hands it to you. Negative closes it out. Either way the follow-up thread stops.

If an Anthropic key is configured, a triage step reads new replies first and suggests a label with a one-line reason. It is a suggestion. Your click is what counts.

A bounce (a mailer-daemon reply) is handled without you: the address is marked invalid, the thread ends, and no mailbox writes to that address again.

Operations



Run the engine by hand, and see what it has been doing

Running a step

Each button runs one piece of the engine and streams its log to the screen. They come in four groups:

Discover goes out and finds new candidates: YouTube channels, Apple Podcasts shows, production companies from Wikidata, the TVF pool import.

Enrich fills in what is missing: the contact address, the channel behind a website, the evidence the scoring needs.

Process turns raw finds into scored leads: deduplicate, promote, score, apply the gates.

Outreach drafts the emails.

You do not normally need any of these. The schedule runs them for you. Use them when you want more leads today, or when you have changed something and want to see the effect now.

Only one job runs at a time. The log panel stays on screen afterwards so you can read what happened.

Mailboxes

The Mailboxes panel shows each sending address, how much it can send today, how much it has already sent, and how much room is left.

New mailboxes **warm up**: ten emails a day to start, five more every two days, up to forty. Three warm mailboxes give 120 a day, which is also the project ceiling. This is not caution for its own sake; a new address that sends eighty cold emails on day one gets filtered, and then none of them arrive.

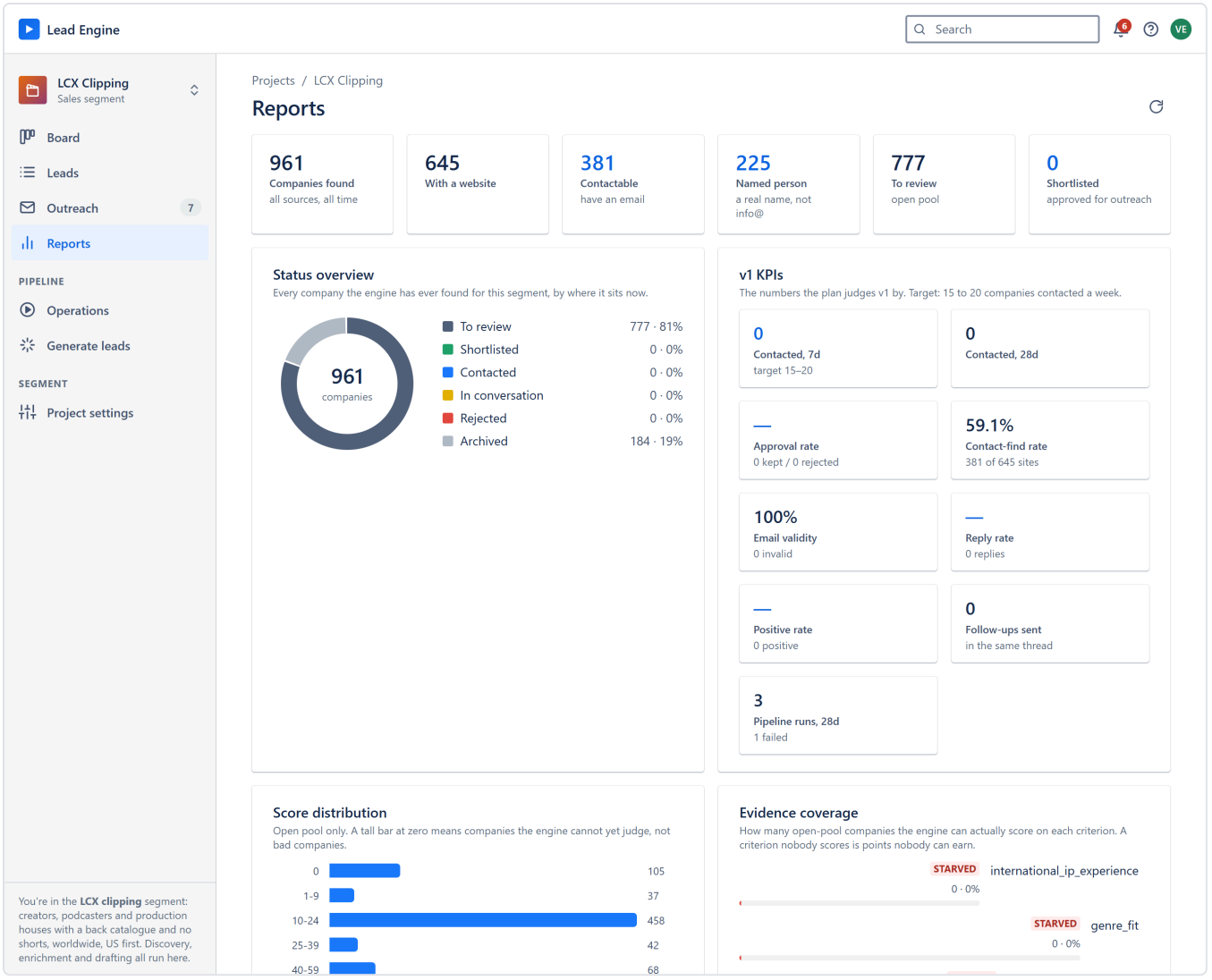
Openers are spread across whichever mailbox has the most room. A follow-up always leaves from the mailbox that sent its opener, because a thread belongs to one mailbox.

Schedule and recent runs

Unattended schedule is what runs without anyone watching, in UTC.

Recent runs is the history: every scheduled or manual run, and the exact step that failed if one did.

Reports



Is this working?

Status overview — every company ever found for this project, and where it sits now.

v1 KPIs — the numbers the plan is judged on. The target is 15 to 20 companies contacted a week.

Score distribution — the open pool by score. A tall bar at zero is not a pile of bad companies; it is companies the engine could not judge yet.

Evidence coverage — how many companies can actually be scored on each criterion. A criterion nobody can be scored on is points nobody can earn, and that is a signal to fix the enrichment, not the rubric.

By source — which connectors are earning their place.

The rules that never bend

These are built into the database, not just into the screens. They hold even if the app has a bug.

No email is ever sent that a person has not read. Approval means a human read that exact text. There is no automatic send, no scheduled send, no "approve all without looking".

One thread per company, ever. An opener and at most two follow-ups. Checked across every project, not just the one you are in, and it survives resets and re-imports.

A rejected lead never comes back. No later harvest will re-import something you turned down.

"Remove me" is permanent. An opt-out request marks that domain unsubscribed forever.

Nothing is claimed that the evidence does not support. Every sentence in an email is built from that lead's own recorded numbers. A lead that already publishes shorts gets no "you publish no shorts" line, because it would not be true of them.

Only public first-party pages are read, and robots.txt is honoured. No LinkedIn scraping. No CAPTCHA bypass. No buying scraped lists.

What only you can do

The engine cannot finish these. Each one needs a person with an account or a card.

1. Fill in the footer. Your name and postal address, in the Footer dialog on the Outreach screen. Until this is done, no email can be approved: the check refuses a draft that still says `SET_ME`.

2. Connect a mailbox. A Gmail OAuth client in Google Cloud, then the address in `.env`, then one browser consent per mailbox:

```
SEGMENT_SLUG=lcx-clipping python tools/outreach.py auth --mailbox main
```

Use addresses on a sending domain that belongs to LCX alone, not the main company domain, so a bad week never touches everyday mail.

3. Draft the emails. In LCX Clipping every lead scoring above 20 is shortlisted automatically, so go to Outreach and press **Draft emails**. Each press drafts up to 20, and a draft whose opening line Groq wrote is approved on its own. In the TVF projects, shortlist leads by hand first.

4. Connect Apollo, for the Universal project. In Apollo: Settings → Integrations → API Keys → Create new key, tick the five endpoints the Apollo search page lists (or turn on *Set as master key*), then put the key in `.env` as `APOLLO_API_KEY` and in Render's Environment tab. Until then the page shows these steps where the results would be.

Optional, and worth having later: an Anthropic key for reply triage, and an alert webhook so a failed overnight run reaches you.

If something looks wrong

"I approved it but nothing was sent." Approving does not send. Someone runs the send command. Check the Approved folder; that is where approved emails wait.

"The screen is blank / says it cannot reach the database." The free cloud instance goes to sleep when it is idle and takes a few seconds to wake. Reload once. If it persists, check Operations for a failed run.

"A lead has no contact." The engine only uses addresses that companies have published themselves. If nobody published one, open the lead: **Contacts** shows every other way in it found (a phone number, the contact page, social profiles) and what it already tried. **Find contacts on sites** reads the website of every lead without a usable address once, shortlisted leads included.

"The greeting says 'Hi there' or just 'Hello,'." That means no person could be named for the address the email goes to, and the engine will not guess. When the lead lists a person at their own address, or a person against a shared inbox like info@, the greeting uses their first name. "Hi there" is correct behaviour; "Hi Tech Talk" would not be.

"A draft will not approve." The dialog names the reason: an unfilled placeholder, a sender that still says `SET_ME`, an address that failed verification, or a company whose status has moved on since the draft was written.

"I rejected something by mistake." Leads list, status filter to Rejected, open it, and change the status with the dropdown at the top right of the dialog.

Words used here

Project (segment) — one sales motion with its own leads, rubric, templates and mailboxes. Switch with the project name at the top of the sidebar.

Lead — one company, show or creator. Has a key like `LCX-CCAB`.

Fit score — out of 100: the points earned out of the rubric's 110 (Project settings), scaled to 100, plus adjustments. Every point is explained in the lead dialog, along with the points nobody has checked yet.

Gate — a hard disqualifier. Fires only on confirmed evidence, never on something the engine failed to check.

Evidence — a fact the engine actually observed, with a record of where it came from.

Draft — an email that has been written and not sent. Inert until approved.

Opener — the first email to a company. **Follow-up** — a later one in the same thread.

Spot check — the random sample the server makes you read before approving a batch.

Warm-up — the ramp on a new mailbox, from ten a day up to forty.

Enrichment — the passes that fill in contacts and evidence on leads already found.